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BLAST FORCE
The site of the IED blast at Aranpur in Dantewada, Chhattisgarh, that killed 10 security personnel on Apr. 26

CHHATTISGARH MAOIST ATTACK

THE PRICE OF COMPLACENCY

By Rahul Noronha

After a gap of almost four years, a major Maoist attack took place in Dantewada in South Chhattisgarh, where left-wing extremists triggered an improvised explosive device (IED) on April 26, killing 10 security personnel and their civilian driver. While bigger and deadlier incidents have rocked Chhattisgarh in the past, the April 26 incident corresponded with claims by the security establishment—perhaps resulting from a lull in violence—that Maoism was on its last legs in the state.

What really happened on April 26? From their Dantewada district headquarters, a party of District Reserve Guard (DRG)—a state force raised for anti-Maoist operations—and Chhattisgarh Armed Force (CAF) personnel left for Aranpur in the intervening night of April 25 and 26 after receiving specific inputs on Maoist presence. Around 6.30 a.m., an engagement took place between Maoists and security forces at Aranpur. Two Maoist Jan Militia (part-time workers of the outlawed CPI-Maoist) members—Lakhma Kawasi and Kosa Madvi, both residents of Sukma district—were arrested. Madvi